

>> aerobics workout

Think of an aerobics workout and the chances are you'll conjure up an image of a class involving women wearing headbands and a lot of Lycra. That's how things were in the 1980s. This sequence offers you my collection of classic aerobic moves. Headbands and Lycra are optional!

The term “aerobics” was first used to describe a system of exercise which an exercise physiologist designed to help prevent heart disease. The system involved doing continuous, rhythmic activity using large muscle groups. In fact, all the sequences in my *15 Minute Calorie Burn Workout* are “aerobic,” which is why they help you to burn calories.

The aerobics classes most of us recognize today have evolved from what started out in the US in the early 1970s and grew into a worldwide craze that became one of the defining features of the 1980s. If you happened to be around then—as I was—you may recall the hype that surrounded these particular classes. The combination of exercise and the social aspect often proved irresistible. And because you could—and still can—work more or less intensively, depending on your ability, one of the advantages of aerobics was that it gave people of different fitness levels the chance to work together and have fun.

My own aerobics workout offers you the chance to do a collection of some classic—what I would call “vintage”—aerobic steps from the early days. Some of the moves, such as the Grapevine, Toe tap, and Rocking horse, were around then, and are often found in classes today.

Many of the steps in this aerobics workout are very simple, so it is important to monitor how hard you are training. Ideally, you should aim to work at a level where you are not too comfortable. If the steps feel easy to you, follow the tips on pages 102–103 to intensify your work rate.

>> tips for your aerobics workout

- **In Chest march**, you have to really relax the shoulders and arms to isolate the chest muscles properly. Your elbows should meet (or nearly meet) as you flex the chest.
- **In Side-dig swing**, don't transfer all your weight to the foot you step out on. Keep your weight centered and “bounce” the step more. This helps you to keep in time.
- **In high-impact steps** such as Crossover jump, be sure to land correctly, flexing your knees and rolling through your feet. Do it safely and don't rush it.

However, some of the steps—for example, Chest march, Side-dig swing, and Crossover jump—need your special attention (see above). And remember: quality is always more important than quantity.

Although you will be doing this workout in the comfort of your own home, imagine yourself in a 1980s class. Let yourself go and have fun. Perform the moves with enthusiasm. You could even get the rest of your family involved!

One of the benefits of doing a regular aerobics workout is that you can perform the steps with an intensity that suits you, and still burn the calories.